

Getting Things Done (GTD) Activity

Step 1. Stockpile (~5 minutes):

Get a pen and paper or open a new Google Doc. Write down every task you can think of that you have to or want to do. No need to organize it, just get everything out onto the page.

Important: Unlike a to-do list, you have to be definite and clear about the item or task on the list. For example, instead of writing *Call Yemi*, you'd need to write *Schedule call with Yemi on Thursday to discuss project budget*.

Step 2. Clarify (5-10 minutes):

For each item you wrote down, clarify it. Break down tasks into their smallest actionable components. So for each item, what is the next actionable step? (Another recommendation is that if it can be done in less than 2 minutes, do it immediately and take just it off your list.)

Step 3. Organize (10-15 minutes):

After completing the first 2 steps, you'll likely have a lengthy list of tasks and ideas you've captured. To effectively manage these items, organize them into specific categories or "park" them in spaces. Here are some spaces (which can be digital or physical) you might "park" them in:

A. Calendar

We recommend that you put all time-sensitive items on your calendar (For example, a doctor's appointment on Tuesday at 10am).

B. Project lists

This list is for all projects and tasks requiring multiple steps to complete (Examples of projects might include a course project, organizing a networking event, or planning a trip.)

C. Reference folder

Store tasks that have value but that don't require immediate action in a reference folder (digital or physical). Items here could include articles you want to read, inspiring quotes you want to revisit, or valuable resources you'd like to check out more thoroughly later.

D. Trash 🗑️

Delete or cross off your list any tasks that you can't work on or don't want to spend time on.

E. Next actions list(s) 💪

Any and all tasks that you can and should accomplish right away go here.

F. Waiting for list 🕒

This is for any tasks that you cannot act on immediately because you are waiting for input, information, or action from someone else. (For example, if you need to know the customer satisfaction scores on a recent survey before you can write a report and you're waiting for your colleague to provide that information, you would add the report-writing task to your waiting for list.

G. Someday/maybe list 💡

This is for ideas or tasks you would like to work on in the future but can't devote time to immediately. These could include personal goals, creative projects, or business ventures you want to explore. For example, hiking to the top of Mt. Kilimanjaro may be on your someday/maybe list because it's not a priority at the moment, but something you'd really like to do in the future.

Step 4. Reflection. (Skip this step for now- but read this and come back to it!):

Reflecting is a **very important** part of the GTD process. This involves taking a step back, looking at what you've accomplished, and deciding what to do next. But you don't need to do it right this second. The GTD system involves two types of reviews:

1. **Daily reviews:** These are shorter reviews carried out daily. It can be at the start of the day or the end of the day. Look through your calendar and the next actions list to determine what needs to be done on that specific day.
2. **Weekly reviews:** The weekly review is the backbone of the GTD system and is a **non-negotiable** component. Set aside at least 30 minutes at the beginning or end of your week (put it in your calendar. Make sure that you've

captured and clarified all incoming tasks and ideas. You should review your projects, active project plans, next actions list, waiting for list, and someday/maybe list.

Without regular reviews, the GTD system will become less effective over time.

Step 5. Engage (time spent is up to you):

Now is the time to pick one action and DO IT! But even with a list of next actions, you might find it hard to know the next right thing to do at any given time. You may have your own method for deciding. Or you can try using David Allen's **four criteria for choosing actions in the moment**:

This model helps you decide which action to take next by considering these factors:

- **Context:** Am I in this the right context for this action? For example, you can reply to an email while on your laptop on the bus, but you can't have a zoom call there.
- **Priority:** Is this the most impactful activity I can do right now? For example, turning in a milestone on time is more important than watching TV.
- **Energy levels:** Do I have enough energy (creative or otherwise) right now to do this? For example, you may choose to do easier tasks like watering your plants instead of creative brainstorming when you are tired.
- **Time available:** Do I have the time to do this now? For example, you can't squeeze a 20-minute task into a 5-minute window before a meeting.